

DoJ appears to ignore New Mexico deadline for key Epstein ranch files

State attorney general set 31 July deadline for documents relating to abuse of girls at Epstein-owned Zorro ranch



📷 The Zorro ranch, formerly owned by Jeffrey Epstein, in this July 2019 picture. Photograph: Drone Base/Reuters

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The US Department of Justice (DoJ) appeared to ignore a Friday deadline set by Raúl Torrez, the attorney general of New Mexico, to share information about the abuse of girls at a remote ranch formerly owned by the disgraced financier and sex offender [Jeffrey Epstein](#).

Torrez's office asked the DoJ in February for unredacted files after he [reopened](#) a dormant criminal investigation into activities at Zorro ranch, a remote 10,000-acre property in desert scrub outside New Mexico.

It set a 31 July deadline for the department to share relevant records. As it approached on Friday, the justice department did not respond to a request for comment.

The Guardian [reported in February](#) that recent releases of the so-called Epstein files included thousands of mentions of the ranch, and numerous photographs of men and young girls there. A succession of survivors had previously given testimony about abuse they were subjected to.

However, unlike other properties prominent in Epstein's sex-trafficking conspiracy in Palm Beach, New York, and his private Caribbean island, no federal search of the ranch was ever confirmed to have taken place.

Torrez set a deadline of Friday for federal prosecutors from the justice department, and the US attorney's office for the southern district of New York (SDNY), which led the original Epstein investigation, to allow access to whatever documents they had.

Despite promises of cooperation from Todd Blanche, the acting attorney general, and Jay Clayton, former US attorney for the SDNY, now director designate of national intelligence, Torrez said only 31 pages were ever handed over.

They were mostly old news clippings and heavily redacted pages of little use to state investigators, he said.

Torrez said in a [14 July letter](#) to Blanche he would "pursue all available legal remedies without further notice" if the 31 July deadline passed, having made "repeated, documented, good-faith efforts to obtain the unredacted investigative records in the USDOJ's custody".

The same week, in [an interview](#) with Albuquerque ABC News affiliate KOAT, Torrez said: "I'm not taking anything off the table. I'm not ruling out a lawsuit."

Epstein died in jail in New York in August 2019 while awaiting trial on child sex trafficking charges. The fight for documents relating to his activities at Zorro ranch, which he bought in 1993 from the estate of the Democratic former New Mexico governor Bruce King, became something of a cat and mouse affair after Torrez's reopening of an inquiry first launched by his predecessor [Hector Balderas](#) in February 2019.

According to the attorney general, the southern district of New York called him in July to announce that it [would not cooperate](#).

But Clayton, in his confirmation hearing in the US Senate last month, told Martin Heinrich, Democratic senator for New Mexico: "My folks, I think as we speak, are seeking dialogue with the attorney general to see if we can reach an accommodation". Clayton noted that the documents were subject to certain "protective orders", namely redactions to hide the identities of victims.

Blanche, accused in February by Democrats of a "[full-blown cover-up](#)" of the Epstein files, told his own confirmation hearing last month that he was "[continuing to work](#)" with the New Mexico department of justice.

But Torrez said he had heard nothing further, either from Blanche, or the SDNY.

Meanwhile, the US attorney's office for the district of New Mexico, in a statement to the Guardian, said it had "substantively responded" to Torrez's request on 30 June by emailing the 31 documents.

Some, a spokesperson said, were communications directing Torrez to the SDNY. The New Mexico US attorney's office "did not lead or handle the Zorro Ranch investigation and therefore neither collected nor retained any investigative materials", the statement said.

Torrez did not respond to a request for comment from the Guardian on Friday. He told MS Now's the Briefing with Jen Psaki [on 23 July](#) that he was

annoyed by months of stonewalling from Blanche, Donald Trump’s pick for attorney general, whose confirmation is [in peril](#).

“It appears that the administration has been really focused on the management of communications around the Epstein case, rather than acting in a way that demonstrates a commitment to getting to the truth and getting to accountability,” said Torrez.

Especially frustrating, he told MS Now, was the conduct of the SDNY after the first, Balderas-ordered investigation was shelved. Torrez said: “We stood down that investigation at the explicit request of the southern district of New York, and so to have them fail to honor their agreement and then not give us access to this file is extremely unusual, and it’s complicating our ability to advance this criminal investigation.”

Blanche “has the authority right now, with the stroke of a pen, to grant us this access, to let us, our investigators and prosecutors, come and take a look at the files, identify co-conspirators, witnesses, corroborating evidence, identify new potential leads,” Torrez added.

“Every day that goes by that that doesn’t happen is another day that we’ve delayed delivering justice for the survivors.”

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